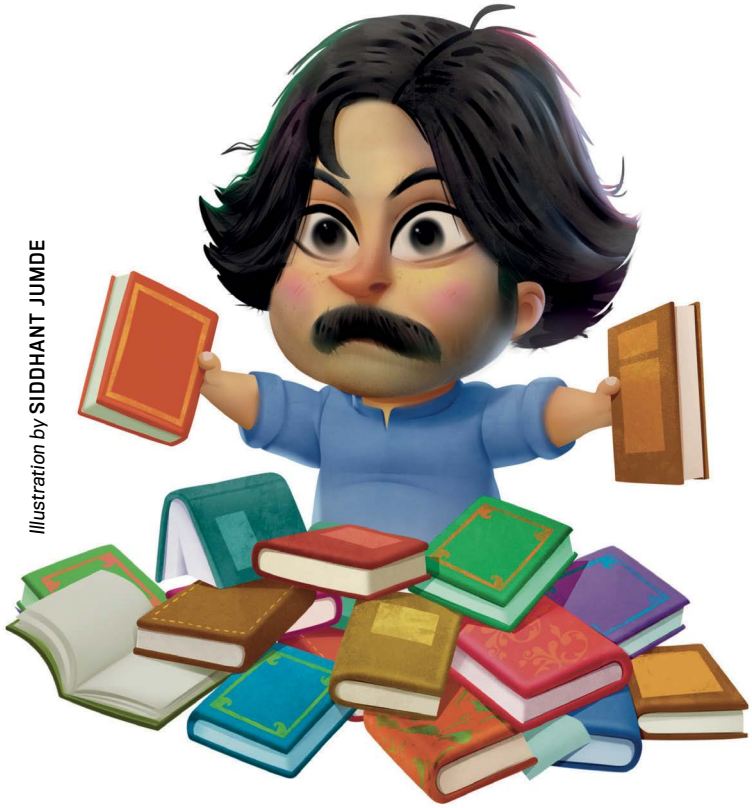


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

A POLITICAL HANDBOOK

A bookish politician is a rare animal these days, but one that takes time out to browse for books, well that's nigh impossible to see. The new Andhra Pradesh deputy CM, 'Power Star' **Pawan Kalyan**, though, is from that mould. After inaugurating the Vijayawada Book Fair on January 2, he returned on the 11th, spending over two hours carefully selecting titles. A self-proclaimed bibliophile, Kalyan plans to set up a library in his Pithapuram constituency. He even surprised many by recommending *Man's Search for Meaning* by Viktor E. Frankl, praising the Nazi prisoner's extraordinary resilience. Maybe he felt that Frankl's message of hope and perseverance mirrors his own journey through the turbulent Andhra political landscape?

DAS BACK AS COMMON MAN



Former Jharkhand CM **Raghubar Das** took a week off after stepping down as Odisha governor on January 2, but then has jumped straight into his home state's political waters. By January 11, he was in full "birthday diplomacy" mode—wishing BJP state chief Babulal Marandi and dropping by JMM patriarch Shibu Soren's house for a friendly hello. But don't let the smiles fool you, Das's return has already stirred up whispers of a challenge to Marandi's leadership. From temple-hopping to mingling with the *janata*, he's on a relentless charm spree. Das has even got a deadly nickname for himself—"CM", short for 'common man'.

Call Drop

In Delhi's power corridors, "*Chai se kettle garam* (Kettle is hotter than the tea)", is the latest buzz phrase, slyly aimed at ministerial staff who are conveniently unavailable to take calls from BJP MPs, party leaders and even RSS functionaries. The frustration boiled over recently when an MP from Uttar Pradesh created a scene at the office of a cabinet minister, calling it a personal insult. The minister later issued an apology. The MPs say this cold-shoulder treatment isn't an isolated affair—it's a pattern in 8-9 ministries.

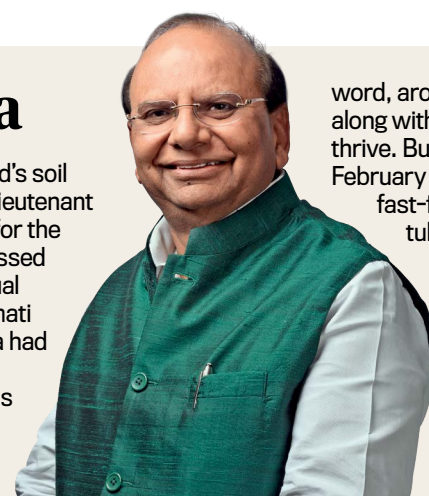
EK THA TIGER



Tiger, tiger, burning bright—now sparking a Bengal-Odisha fight. Bengal CM **Mamata Banerjee** was miffed when Zeenat, the tigress who strayed from Odisha's Similipal forests and wandered through five districts of Bengal, had to be promptly returned after her capture. "Our foresters rescued her, and they asked us to send her back—so we did," Mamata remarked, accusing Odisha of letting more tigers into Bengal. Unsurprisingly, Odisha's BJP-led government bristled. Forest minister Ganeshram Khuntia flatly denied the claims, saying no other tiger had crossed over. Clearly, the roar of politics is louder than Zeenat's.

Blooming Idea

Will Delhi's tulips find Ahmedabad's soil hospitable this spring? Delhi Lieutenant Governor **V.K. Saxena**'s fondness for the vibrant blooms has now officially crossed state lines. Last year, during the annual flower show at Ahmedabad's Sabarmati riverfront, Ahmedabad native Saxena had promised Gujarat CM Bhupendrabhai Patel a touch of tulip magic. True to his word, around 1,000 tulip bulbs have arrived, along with two gardeners to ensure they thrive. But here's the catch: Gujarat's notorious February heat often skips spring altogether, fast-forwarding straight to summer. If the tulips manage to bloom, they'll be as much a marvel as a miracle.



RAJWANT RAWAT

Kaushik Deka with Amarnath K. Menon, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Amitabh Srivastava, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Jumana Shah